Yale Outdoors Safety and Risk Management Policy

Based on Princeton University's Outdoor Action Guide to Developing a Safety Management Program for an Outdoor Organization by Rick Curtis

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Introduction

Yale Outdoors aims to meet its safety obligations to trip participants and its leaders through a comprehensive and responsible safety management policy. Yale Outdoors builds safety into every activity and educates all stakeholders about safety measures.

Leaders Training

Yale Outdoors serves community members with all levels of outdoors experience and thus must provide a safe environment for participants who do not yet have the experience and judgment to understand and protect themselves from potential risk. This involves educating participants on how to skillfully conduct themselves outdoors both safely and with proper respect for the wilderness. This educational role is taken on by the trip leader, who teaches skills to those with less experience and manages the safety of the group.

Given that Yale Outdoors is a non-professional organization, the required skills of a leader should scale with the difficulty of the trip to provide a base standard of safety. The judgement of trip difficulty should be made on a per-trip basis, but should be based on the following factors: i) Distance from Yale (driving or non-driving, other forms of transportation); ii) Duration of trip (multi-day, overnight or day trip); and iii) Activity Difficulty (e.g. rock climbing or canoeing vs. hiking).

Required Skills

Skill	Trip Difficulty	Notes
Activity Experience	Basic	Leader must have had experience in the activity being conducted.
First Aid	Basic	One leader must be **WFA** and **CPR** certified. Leader must be equipped with a first aid kit. Leader must also bring the First Aid Manual.
Safety and Risk Management	Basic	Leader must submit a trip proposal and all participant liability forms. Leader must also note the Emergency Procedures. There should be a **pre-trip email** covering the main safety points for participants.
Leadership and Group Dynamics	Basic	There must be an appointed trip lead (one person) and medical lead. They do not need to be the same person. Leader must also bring the First Aid Manual.

Driving	Basic	If driving is involved, leader must complete the Driver Safety Awareness online course https://bmsweb.med.yale.edu/tms/tms_enrollments.offerings?p_std_id=85672&p_crs_id=2208.
Activity Experience	Intermediate	Leader must have had extensive experience in the activity, preferably including some formal training.
First Aid	Intermediate	Leader must be **WFA** and **CPR** certified. Leader must be equipped with a first aid kit. Leader must also bring the First Aid Manual. For overnights, there should be one leader with **WFR** certification.
Safety and Risk Management	Intermediate	Leader must submit a trip proposal and all participant liability forms. Leader must also note the Emergency Procedures. Leader must conduct a **pre-trip meeting** with participants to go over trip logistics and safety. Leader must note medical evacuation plans.
Leadership and Group Dynamics	Intermediate	There must be an appointed trip lead (one person) and medical lead. They do not need to be the same person. There should be additional leaders with a clear chain of command in case of emergency. Roles should be designated before the trip.
Driving	Intermediate	If driving is involved, leader must complete the Driver Safety Awareness online course https://bmsweb.med.yale.edu/tms/tms_enrollments.offerings?p_std_id=85672&p_crs_id=2208.
Activity Experience	Hard	Leader must have had extensive experience in the activity, preferably including some formal training.
First Aid	Hard	Leader must be **WFR** certified. Leader must be equipped with a first aid kit. Leader must also bring the First Aid Manual.
Safety and Risk Management	Hard	Leader must submit a trip proposal and all participant liability forms. Leader must

		also note the Emergency Procedures. Leader must conduct a **pre-trip meeting** with participants to go over trip logistics and safety. Leader must prepare medical evacuation plans.
Leadership and Group Dynamics	Hard	There must be an appointed trip lead (one person) and medical lead. They do not need to be the same person. There should be additional leaders with a clear chain of command in case of emergency. Roles should be designated before the trip.
Driving	Hard	If driving is involved, leader must complete the Driver Safety Awareness online course https://bmsweb.med.yale.edu/tms/tms_enrollments.offerings?p_std_id=85672&p_crs_id=2208.

Trip Planning

Trip planning is essential to operating a safe program. There are a number of elements to consider when planning a trip

- **Route** - what maps will be used, what trails will be followed
- **Weather Conditions**
- **Equipment Needed**
    - Personal Equipment - what does the individual participant provide, what (if anything) does the organization provide.
    - Group Equipment - what does the organization provide (such as a first aid kit).
- **File a Trip Plan** - whenever a trip goes out, a trip plan indicating the planned route and planned time of return should be filed with the Expedition Coordinator. This person should be contacted when the group returns. If the group does not return by a designated time, a procedure should be in place for what to do (call the rangers, etc.)
- **Who is in Charge?** - it is important that everyone understand who is in charge and under what circumstances. In the case of a trip with designated leaders, they would typically be in charge unless someone else in the group has more experience (for example, a participant with more medical experience such as a EMT or physician might be the most appropriate individual to appoint as the medical lead of the trip). Trips require a minimum of two leaders, and one of these two leaders is to be the point person for the trip, and the first in the chain of command.
- **Emergency Protocols** - there should be some understood protocols for dealing with common emergencies (see policies, procedures, and guidelines below).

Participant Screening

Participants often vary widely in terms of competence, enthusiasm, and preparation. Leaders must select participants carefully prior to the trip.

Factor	Notes
Medical History (Confidential - only on a need to know basis)	● Health History ● Allergies ● Medications ● Dietary restrictions ● Required Immunizations ● Chronic medical conditions - blood disorders, epilepsy, etc.
Physical Condition	Whether the person is physically capable of safely participating in the activity at the indicated difficulty level or, if the activity itself is based on the participants who sign up, what level of trip should be planned.
Experience	Certifications and outdoors experience.
Other Information	● Address and phone ● Medical Insurance Provider ● Who to contact in an emergency ● Permission for medical treatment ● Equipment Needs ● Special Needs

Difficulty Analysis

The analysis should include:

- **Activities** - the types of program activities (canoeing, hiking, rock climbing, etc.) will all have different types of Environmental Hazards and potential accidents
    - What are the risk management factors in the activity? Which can be controlled and which cannot be controlled?
    - What skills are needed by participants?
    - What skills are needed by leaders?
    - What equipment is needed?
    - What training in the use of the equipment is needed by leaders, participants?
- **Participants** - there are a number of factors in the participants that you program for that can have impacts on safety. These include:
    - Age of participants

    - Previous experience - programs that are introducing new people to outdoor activities versus programs that are providing activities for experienced outdoors persons or program with a mix of both.
    - Physical condition
    - Mental & emotional condition
- **Locations** - the location of the activity is also an important factor
    - How much travel and what type is required to get to the activity and return?
    - How will the participants or group travel? Individual cars, group vehicle, who is driving?
    - How remote is the activity? Activities which are more remote may require additional support and have less chance for rescue in an emergency. This may require the group to operate at a lower level of difficulty than in an area closer to emergency services. For example, paddlers on remote whitewater rivers will often increase the rating of a rapid by one class because of the remoteness (a Class IV rapid would be considered a Class V in terms of the consequences if something goes wrong).
- **Weather** - typical weather for the activity, location, and season will be a significant factor in determining the experience level, physical condition, age, and experience level of those who are appropriate to go on a trip.

Pre-trip Meeting

Participants need to be informed about a number of things before a trip goes out.

- **Activity** - type of activity, location, duration
- **Skill level/Difficulty level of the activity** - the potential challenges of the trip and skills that the participants are expected to have. Ensure that each participant is aware of the difficulty so that they may choose to remove themselves from the trip, or the trip can be modified to accommodate everyone's needs. As mentioned above, it is crucial for the entire group's safety to screen your participants for more difficult trips.
- **Equipment Needed** - what the participants needs to provide and what if anything the organization will provide. In some cases, participants who do not have the proper equipment would not be permitted to go.
- **Policies** - participants need to be informed in advance of policies of the organization (such as no alcohol or drugs, no non-members, etc.)
- **Waivers, Assumption of Risk forms, etc.** - all participants are required to fill out a liability form before they are permitted to depart on a trip. If they choose not to sign the waiver they will be unable to participate.

Emergency Procedures

Basic Procedure:

1. **Call 911**
2. **Notify a co-coordinator of the organization**

3. **Stay calm and apply appropriate first aid**

The primary trip lead takes charge in the event of an emergency. If it is a medical emergency, the medical lead will take charge of the medical situation while the trip lead fulfills the other elements of emergency procedure. Should the medical lead and primary trip leader be the same person, the second in command should fulfil other emergency procedures while the medical lead administers care. Note that depending on the type of emergency, there might be different people who would take charge. In the event of a lost person, it might be the person with the most backpacking or search and rescue experience who executes the skills required to attend to the specific emergency. It is crucial to determine who will fulfill these roles before the trip departs so that there will be no confusion in the event of an emergency situation.

General Emergency Procedure, Completed by Primary Trip Leader

1. **Assess the Situation:** determine the nature of the emergency and what type of response is required (first aid, search for a lost person, etc.).
2. **Assume leadership of the group and delegate responsibility:** group members should assist in patient care if needed, locate position on map, prepare a camp with shelter and food, etc.
3. **Develop a Response Plan**: based on the nature of the emergency, develop an appropriate response plan (first aid treatment, initiate search, etc.)
4. **Reassess Situation and Re-plan:** Continue to reassess the situation and alter the response plan if necessary.

Non-medical elements of dealing with a medical emergency:

- Give the other group members something to do to get their minds off the situation and make them feel useful
- Set up a temporary camp and form of shelter both for the injured individual and the rest of the group
- Check in with the other group members, and asses their needs. This may be emotional or mental trauma in response to emergency situation.
- Ensure that the entire group is staying hydrated, fed, and warm.

Evacuation Procedures

If someone needs to be evacuated due to injury or illness, the primary concern is for the safety and health of the patient. When assessing the need for an evacuation, think both about the patient's condition and how rapidly medical attention is needed. For example, it may take 2 hours for the patient to walk out on their own. Whereas to send two people out for help (2 hours), get a rescue squad to the trailhead (1 hour), hike back in (2 hours - unless driving in is possible), and hike back out (2 hours+) will mean over 7 hours before the patient is evacuated. Their injury may need treatment sooner than that. You must also consider your resources: do you have the necessary equipment, person power, and experience to safely evacuate the

person given the current trail and weather conditions? If you do evacuate the person, take the time to plan out the best route keeping in mind patient condition, distance, terrain, etc. Depending on the situation, you might chose the shortest route, the quickest route, or a longer route that poses less threat to the patient's condition.

Possible Evacuation Scenarios

1. Person can walk out on his/her own power: The person's medical condition would not be compromised by walking out. This may necessitate taking all the person's equipment. Ex. Stomach ailment, mild allergic reaction, minor laceration.
2. Person can walk out with assistance: If the distance is not too great, the person may be able to hike out if carrying no weight and with assistance. This is to be attempted only as long as it does not aggravate the individual's condition. The person must be constantly monitored.
3. Person cannot walk out: The injury/illness would be aggravated by walking out or movement is contraindicated. Do not attempt a litter evacuation unless you have the necessary equipment, experience, and manpower, otherwise you risk additional injury to your patient as well as placing other members of the group at risk In this case a litter evacuation by skilled rescue personnel (rangers, first aid squad, etc.) is required. Send for help

Choosing to Evacuate

If you have determined that it is medically appropriate to evacuate your patient, you need to determine whether or not you have the skills, the time and the manpower to perform the evacuation safely. Ask yourself these questions.
How much daylight do you have?
What is the weather? Is it changing? For the worse?
Can you continue to provide the necessary first aid treatment and monitoring during the evacuation?
What if your patient's condition deteriorates? Would it be more difficult to treat them once you start hiking out?
How many people do you have to do the evacuation? For a litter evacuation you should plan to have a minimum of 3 teams of 6-8 people rotating through the litter carry.

Choosing to Evacuate in a Non-Medical Situation

Situations other than a medical emergency may arise, and it is at the discretion of the trip leader as to when it is an appropriate measure. This is a decision that should be made in concert with the co-leader, but it is ultimately the decision of the primary leader. The most likely cause of a non-medical evacuation is dangerously worsening weather conditions.

First Aid Manual

American Red Cross Wilderness and Remote First Aid Emergency Reference Guide

Trip Follow-Up

When an accident occurs, it is essential to collect detailed information about what happened, analyze it carefully, and determine if there are changes that need to be made in the program to reduce the possibility of a similar incident occurring in the future.

Accident and Close-Call Reporting

An accident or close-call report must be sent by the trip leader to the Expedition Coordinator and Co-Coordinators, who will then implement structural changes to prevent similar incidents.

- Date and time
- Location
- Description of accident or near-accident
- Participants involved
- Injuries sustained
- Actions taken